The Rosetta Stone

The Rosetta Stone is a fragment of a larger granodiorite stele inscribed in 196 BC, during the reign of Ptolemy V. It records a decree issued by a council of priests at Memphis that confirmed the royal cult. The decree is written three times: in Egyptian hieroglyphs, in Demotic script and in Ancient Greek.

French soldiers found the stone in July 1799 near the town of Rashid, called Rosetta by Europeans, in the Nile Delta, during Napoleon's campaign in Egypt. After the French defeat, the Treaty of Alexandria of 1801 gave the stone to Britain, and it has been in the British Museum since 1802.

Because scholars could read Ancient Greek, the Greek text gave a key to the other two. Thomas Young showed in the 1810s that some hieroglyphs spell the name of Ptolemy inside cartouches. Jean-Francois Champollion announced in 1822 that hieroglyphs combine phonetic signs with signs for ideas, which opened the reading of ancient Egyptian.